FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Terrorism is war by other means. It's a war waged by cowards, especially when they attack unarmed innocent civilians. This is what happened when four armed terrorists murdered 25 tourists and one local on the green meadows of Pahalgam. In Kashmir's long tryst with violence, it marks the worst terror attack on civilians in the past two decades. The hand of Pakistan's ruling establishment is evident. What goaded Pakistan into this misadventure is easy to see. Internally, it faces insurrection along two fronts. The Pakistani Taliban is raising hell on the Afghan border, and Afghanistan is no friend either. Adding to its troubles is the Balochistan situation. This is at its most incendiary phase ever, with militant violence and state crackdowns claiming over 1,000 lives since 2024. Pakistan has also dropped off the list of America's geostrategic favourites, and its economy lives hand to mouth on an ongoing $7 billion IMF bailout. China's vision of using Pakistan as a transit zone, too, is now hampered with its highways running into the Baloch quicksand. As for the political process, it has not entirely recovered from the charismatic Imran Khan's troubled exit from the stage. The present army chief Gen. Asim Munir's tenure has seen the deposed premier's arrest but has done nothing to arrest the dip in the army's popularity on the street.

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Even so, from a logical perspective it is surprising that Pakistan should undertake such a high-risk gamble over whose outcome it will have little control. It was once called a bonsai democracy but is now a broken state which simply cannot afford a war with its bigger and more prosperous neighbour. But Gen. Munir seems to have his own agenda in ratcheting up the temperature with India. In a speech just a week before the massacre, he provocatively called Kashmir Pakistan's "jugular vein". Perhaps the logic behind the Pahalgam attack was to create a 'spectacular' diversion in Kashmir. The timing with US vice-president J.D. Vance's visit to India would attract global attention. There is a pattern to this. In 2000, during President Bill Clinton's visit to India, 35 Sikh villagers were killed by Lashkar-e-Toiba gunmen in the Chattisinghpora massacre. Domestically, such incidents appeal to the hotheads and create an illusion of purpose. India's narrative of normalcy on Kashmir was also hurting Pakistan, especially with a long lull in violence and the beginning of the tourist season registering an unprecedented boom.

Pakistan may expect India to repeat the pattern of retaliation it adopted after Uri and Pulwama. It might even want it. But a hard military action by no means exhausts India's strategic canvas. India has already acted on a range of non-military punitive steps. A day after Pahalgam, the Modi government suspended the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 with immediate effect, until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism. No one has turned off the tap just yet, but Pakistan's two key provinces, Punjab and Sindh, can hurt in the long run if India expedites its dam projects. An informal naval blockade of ports, or the targeting of oil supplies, is another option. Diplomatic ties have been downgraded from cold to frozen.

The occasion demands there be a demonstrative nature to the response. One option is a kind of 'Balakot Plus', combining a 2019-type air strike on terror camps inside Pakistan with a surgical strike across the LoC, like the one after the Uri attacks in 2016 in which our commandos killed an estimated 150 militants. India's target would be the 42 active terrorist launch pads across the LoC, with squads of about 110-130 gunmen. One can also assume the ceasefire on the LoC is now defunct and it will probably be lit up with an aggressive exchange of fire. The Modi government has acted with maturity and not taken any hasty action despite emotions running high and the outcry from the public for revenge. The prime minister has issued a stern warning. He said: "India will identify, trace and punish every terrorist and their backers." The use of the word 'backers' was deliberate. It clearly refers to the Pakistan army. The Pakistan establishment should remember that Modi does not flinch from taking bold decisions. These may not be immediate but are likely to be conclusive. Covert operations can neutralise terror capabilities with precision. A notch or two above that would be a tactical missile strike on the headquarters of the main terror outfits. But that needs a calculation of its own effect: an escalatory ladder where Pakistan's fingers too will hover nervously over buttons that can fire everything from conventional missiles to tactical nukes. New Delhi may calibrate its steps away from the threshold of full-scale war. It wouldn't want to cede the initiative to world powers, which Pakistan's suspension of the Simla Agreement can enable, and thus miss its objectives. The idea is to design a response that delivers lasting and absolute deterrence.

Pakistan must realise the ground has shifted. Even Kashmir has seen protests against terror. Pahalgam perhaps represents a turning point that old-school merchants of violent jehad have failed to notice. New Delhi must ensure the strategists at Islamabad and Rawalpindi are never again emboldened to repeat this. India has been placed in a position where a response is inevitable. How the government proceeds with its many options will shape the subcontinent's immediate future. If it succeeds, it could become Prime Minister Modi's greatest legacy.

(Aroon Purie)